were not much above pre-World War II levels.[84] One can imagine that the situation in the more isolated economies of Soviet-dominated Eastern Europe was even less rosy.

In the meantime, Budapest in 1956 and Prague in 1968 rose against the inhuman face of Communism. Both revolutions were quashed by Soviet tanks.[85] (As a response, Yugoslav ideologists developed the concept of 'Socialism with a human face'.) Some more positive signs came with the cautious normalisation of relations between West Germany and East Germany at the beginning of the 1970s. Then, in 1975, the permanent Conference on Security and Cooperation in Europe (later transformed into what is now known as the Organisation for Security and Cooperation in Europe[86]) was established in Helsinki. Eastern European countries also joined it (they were allowed to do so by Moscow) and this marked the beginning of an easing of Cold War tension. In the meantime, Yugoslavia, which was not a member of the Warsaw Treaty, had been conducting a separate and largely independent foreign policy by launching the non-aligned movement in 1961, composed of mainly third-world countries with Yugoslavia and India as the leaders. Romania too was allowed a degree of independence in international affairs.[87]

But it was not only about security policy in Europe. Encouraged by the (rather timid) human-rights agenda of the Conference on Security and Cooperation in Europe papers, Czechoslovak political opponents, led by Vaclav Havel, founded the Charter 77 movement in that same year. Three years later, the economic difficulties in Poland reached their height and the Solidarity movement was founded. General Jaruzelski declared martial law after six months of protests, allegedly to prevent Soviet invasion. This was also the year of Tito's death, which was soon followed by troubles in Kosovo and then by the Yugoslav debt crisis.

Thus, while Yugoslavia was nearing a catastrophe, Central Europe was moving towards democracy. In 1989, Solidarity won the elections and formed a government, triggering democratisation movements all over Eastern Europe. Led by intellectuals, above all writers and former dissidents, people filled the streets and squares, demanding change. This process took different forms in different countries across the region and different lengths of time to run its course, reflecting local conditions. But it is important to note that, in almost all places except Romania and Yeltsin's